



## LABORATORY ACTIVITY NO. 1.2.2

### Navigating the Windows User Interface

In this laboratory activity, you will sign in to your computer and explore the features of the Start Screen, desktop, and taskbar. If you are using a new computer, a wizard may run to help you set up your computer (choose a username and password and so on). Refer to the computer's setup guide to complete this, then continue with the lab. It is assumed you are using Windows 11 22H2 Update at the least. If you are not, steps might vary slightly.

## I. OBJECTIVES

Upon completion of this laboratory exercise, students are expected to and meet the following intended learning outcomes:

| Activity Objectives                                                                                                                                                  | Intended Learning Outcomes |      |      |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------|------|------|
|                                                                                                                                                                      | ILO1                       | ILO2 | ILO3 |
| 1. successfully sign in to a computer and navigate the Windows Start Screen, including customizing tile layouts and accessing various applications and settings      | •                          | •    |      |
| 2. effectively explore and utilize features of the Windows desktop and taskbar, including opening, managing, and switching between multiple applications and windows | •                          | •    |      |
| 3. configure basic taskbar and Start menu settings, understand how to minimize/maximize windows, and properly shut down the computer system                          | •                          | •    |      |

Where:

- ILO1 – Exhibit thorough demonstration of the concept
- ILO2 – Being able to perform the activity independently
- ILO3 – Design and evaluate emerging IT solutions

## II. DISCUSSION

**Module Objectives:** Upon completion of this unit, users should be able to set up a computer system with regard for safety and healthy working practices, and effectively navigate an operating system (OS) and use input devices.

**Setting Up a PC System:**



- **Environmental Considerations:** Factors like dust, dirt, heat, cold, and dampness can damage computers, so the environment should be suitable.
- **Safety:** Installation must be safe for users and passers-by, considering electrical and trip hazards.
- **Health:** Improper computer use (especially mouse and keyboard) can lead to health risks.
- **Basic Setup Steps:**
  - Check box contents and read instruction manuals, allowing components to adjust to room temperature to prevent condensation.
  - Read manufacturer's setup and safety guidelines and plan installation accordingly.
  - Position monitor and system unit for neat cable management, avoiding walkways. When lifting heavy objects, take care of your back, and ensure objects on desks are stable.
  - Ensure adequate airflow around components like the monitor, system unit, printer, or scanner.
  - Check that the screen is not exposed to excessive glare or direct sunlight.
  - Adjust monitor, chair, mouse, and keyboard for comfortable user posture.
  - Connect peripherals with appropriate, undamaged cables and use cable management.
  - Connect power cables to electrical outlets, checking for damage and correct fuse ratings, and avoiding overloading outlets.
  - Switch on peripherals first, then the system unit by pressing the power switch. If it doesn't start, check power cable connections and wall socket.

### Setting Up a Laptop:

- Follow similar principles: read the manual and allow acclimatization.
- Insert the battery pack and connect the AC adapter for initial charging.
- While peripherals are optional, plug in any desired components.
- Open the lid and press the power switch or key to start the laptop.

### Ergonomic Concepts:

- Ergonomics is the study of factors affecting human performance at work, with poor environments leading to health issues and decreased productivity.
- **Repetitive Strain Injury (RSI):**
  - Caused by repetitive tasks using the same muscles, leading to pain, numbness, tingling, and loss of strength.
  - Linked to keyboard and mouse use.
  - Recommendations include keeping wrists straight, resting palms on the mouse, forearms parallel to the keyboard, avoiding bent wrists/hunched shoulders, and taking frequent breaks.
  - Ergonomically designed keyboards, molded mice, and mouse mats can reduce strain.
- **Sitting Position and Monitor Placement:**



- Poor sitting posture can cause back pain, especially during long periods.
- Monitors should be adjustable to eye level or slightly below, chairs should support the back and neck, feet flat on the floor, and thighs parallel to the floor.
- Avoid hunching shoulders and take frequent breaks.
- Use a copyholder for source documents to maintain eye-level text.

### Navigating an OS (Microsoft Windows 10 as an example):

- **OS Function:** Provides a stable environment for software applications, controls hardware access, and offers configuration and file management tools (e.g., Notepad, Paint).
- **Vendor-Neutral Exam:** CompTIA ITF+ does not ask detailed Windows questions; Windows 10 is used for practical learning, with skills being transferable to other OS versions.
- **Key Tasks:** Master signing into Windows, starting applications, and using desktop features.

### Signing In to Windows:

- **Boot Process:** Computer performs a Power-On Self-Test (POST) and loads Windows, displaying a Lock Screen.
- **Sign-in Purpose:** Saves personal desktop settings and may grant network access.
- **Authentication:** Users receive or create sign-in IDs (username and password) to authenticate account ownership.
- **Steps:** Press a key/click mouse/swipe to open the sign-in prompt. Select your account icon, type your case-sensitive password (shown as dots), and press Enter or click the arrow button.
- **Windows Hello:** Windows 10 supports PIN, fingerprint, or facial recognition for sign-in with appropriate hardware.

### Using the Desktop and Taskbar:

- **Desktop:** Contains shortcut icons for applications, folders, and files.
- **Taskbar:** Manages open windows, usually at the bottom of the desktop. Can be moved and resized if unlocked. The "Automatically hide the taskbar" setting can make it disappear when not in use.
- **Switching Windows:** Click program icons on the taskbar, use ALT+TAB, or START+TAB (Task View) to switch between open applications. Touch-enabled screens allow swiping from the left edge.
- **Icon Behavior:** Icons show previews of open windows on hover. Right-clicking an icon brings up a shortcut (context) menu with options like closing the program or accessing recent documents.



- **Pinned Icons:** Frequently used programs can be "pinned" to the taskbar, remaining there even when closed. Pinned items can be added, removed, or repositioned by dragging.
- **Notification Area:** On the right side of the taskbar, displays time and icons for background programs (e.g., anti-virus, volume, network status). Icons have shortcut menus for configuration. Can be configured to show/hide icons and manage notifications. Touchscreens allow swiping from the right for notifications.

### Using the Start Screen:

- Accessed by clicking the Start button or pressing the START key.
- Manages apps and PC settings, and launches desktop software.
- Displays in full-screen in tablet mode (often automatic on hybrid devices), otherwise as a menu. Tablet mode can be manually selected in settings.
- In tablet mode, "All apps" icon shows all applications. In desktop mode, apps are displayed on the left side of the Start menu.

## III. MATERIALS

A Windows 11 installed computer system.

## IV. PROCEDURE

For this activity, you will execute the provided step-by-step instructions. As you complete each step, capture a screenshot of the resulting output or completed action that directly demonstrates successful execution of that instruction. Paste each screenshot into the designated area within your lab document.

### Important Considerations:

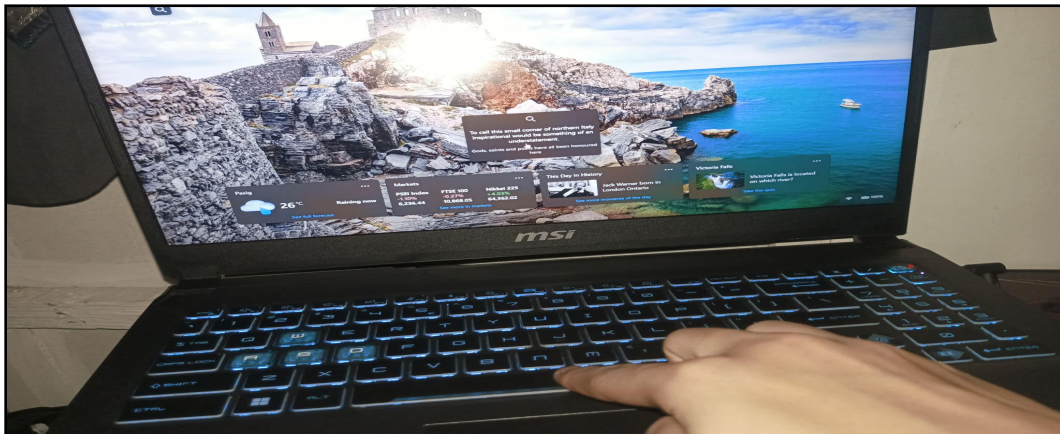
- **Centered Taskbar and Start Button:** The taskbar is now centered on the screen, and the Start button is located in the middle-left of the taskbar.
- **Redesigned Start Menu:** The Start Menu no longer features Live Tiles. Instead, it has a simple layout with pinned apps and a "Recommended" section for files.
- **Snap Layouts:** Windows 11 introduces a new and intuitive way to arrange windows. Hover over the maximize button to see different layout options, which is more advanced than the snap feature in Windows 10.
- **Settings App:** The Settings app in Windows 11 has been completely redesigned. Accessing Taskbar settings is done by right-clicking the taskbar directly, which opens the relevant section of the Settings app.
- **Tablet Mode:** Windows 11's tablet mode is more adaptive and automatic than its Windows 10 counterpart, adjusting the interface dynamically when a convertible device is used.



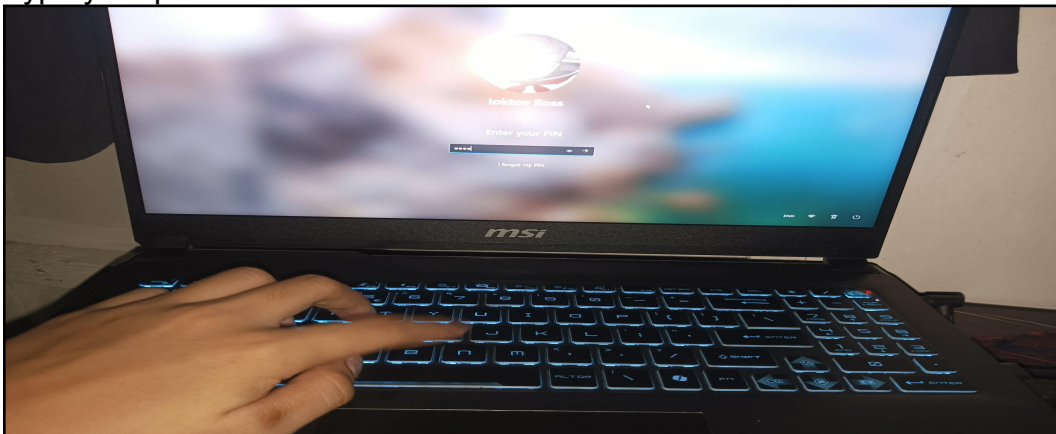
## Steps:

### Part I: Exploring the Start Menu

1. Press a key or click to open the Lock Screen. If necessary, click your user account icon.

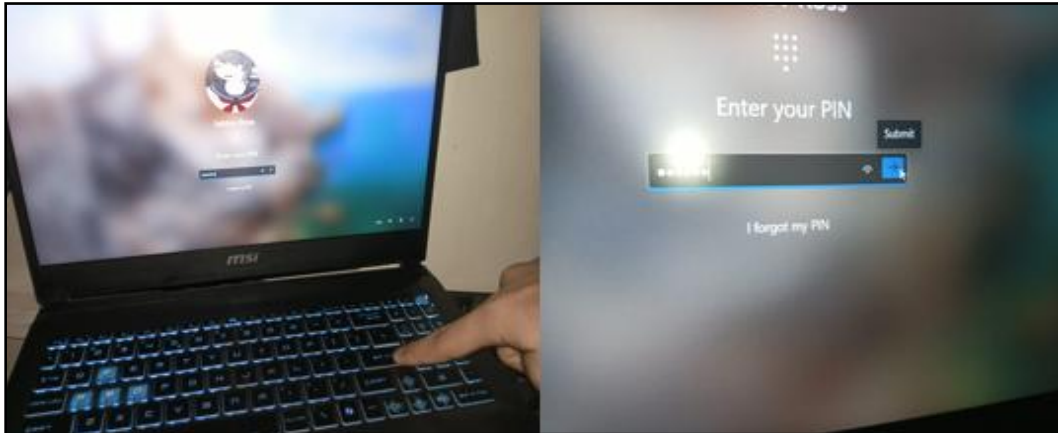


2. Type your password.

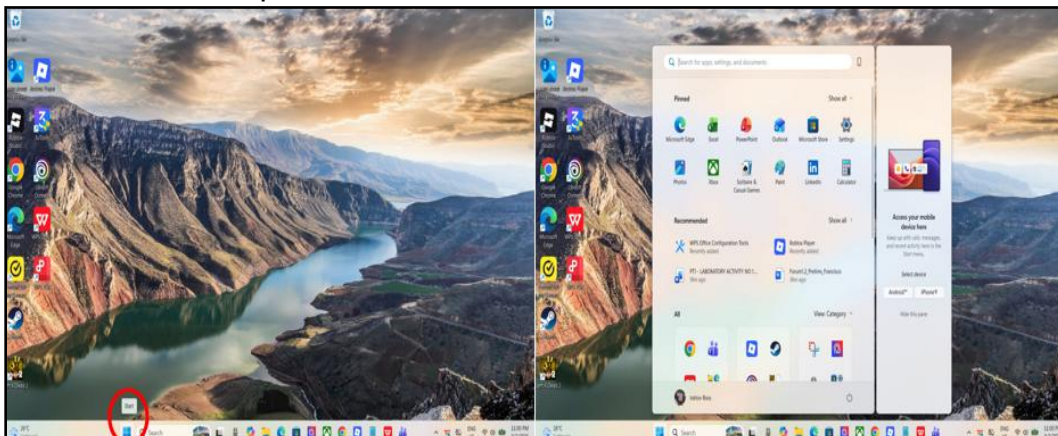




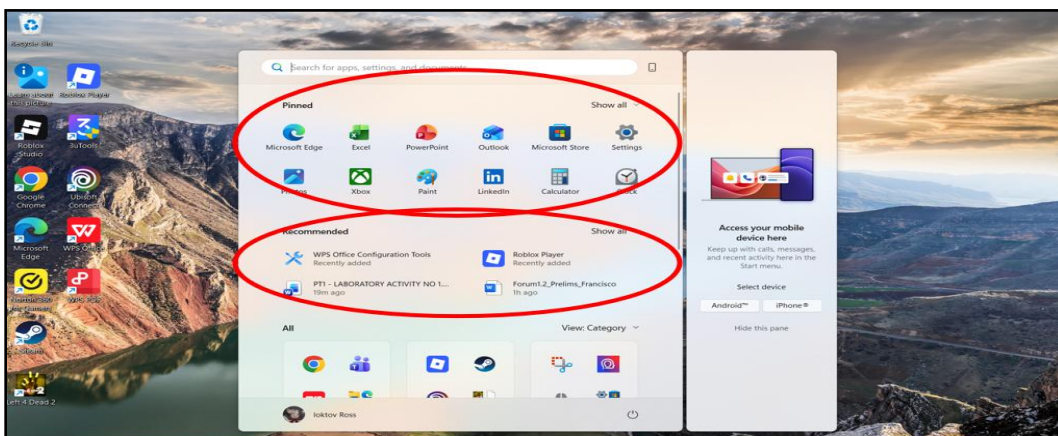
3. Press **ENTER** or click the arrow button to load the desktop.



4. Point to the **Start** button (the Windows logo) located in the center of the taskbar and click once to open the Start Menu.

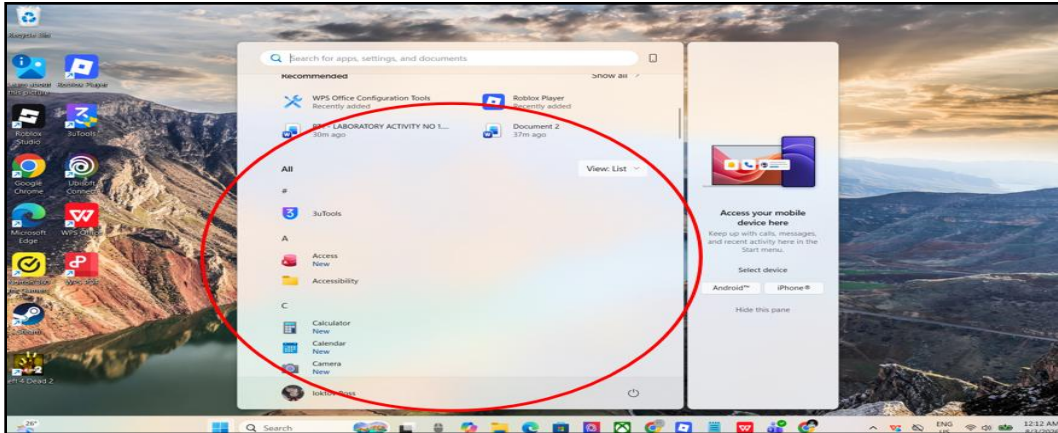


5. Notice the simplified layout with "Pinned" apps at the top and "Recommended" files below.

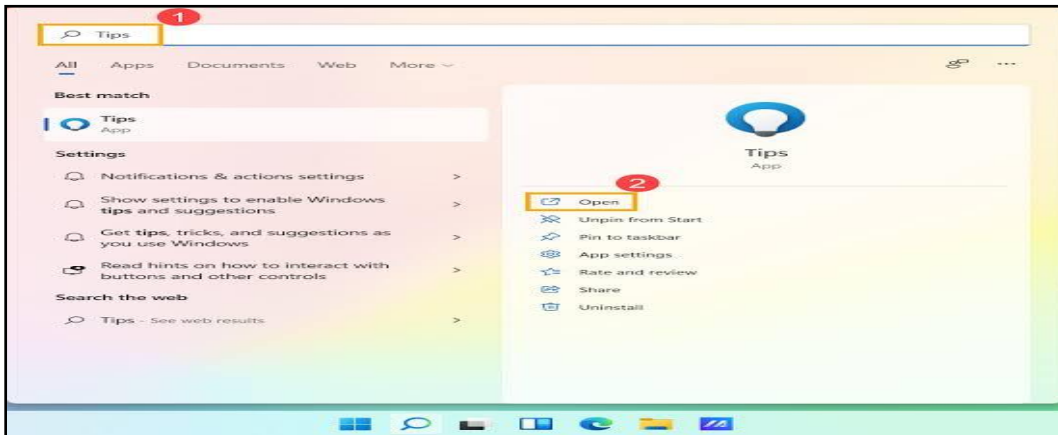




6. To see all installed applications, click **All apps** in the top-right corner of the Start Menu.



7. Locate and click the **Tips** app (or a similar introductory app) and read a few of its articles.



Source: <https://www.asus.com/support/faq/1044697/>

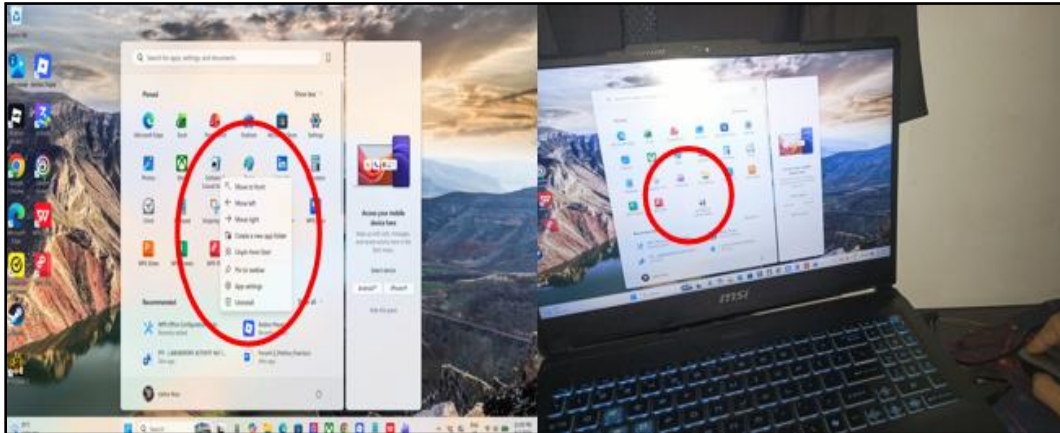
8. To return to the Start Menu, press the **START** key again.



9. Back on the Start Menu, practice customizing the Pinned section by right-clicking a pinned app and selecting **Unpin from Start**. You can also drag and drop icons



to rearrange their order.

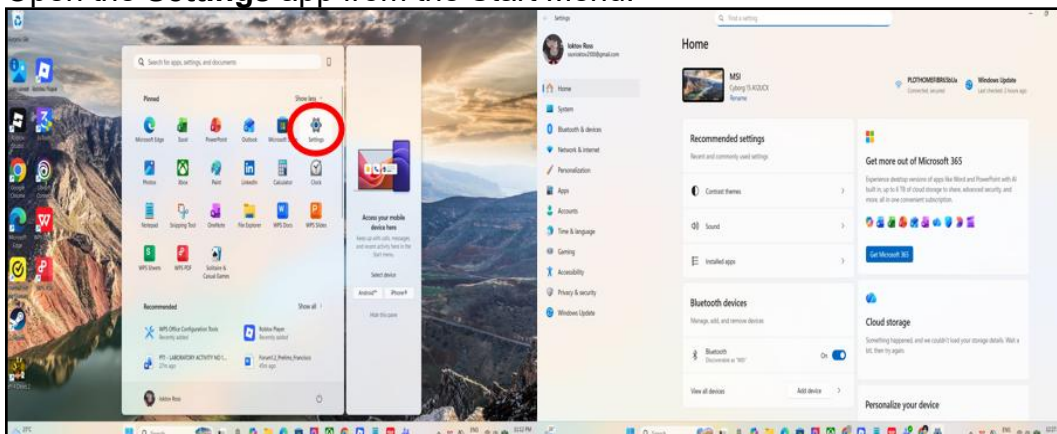


10. Close the Tips app by clicking the **X** in the top-right corner of its window.



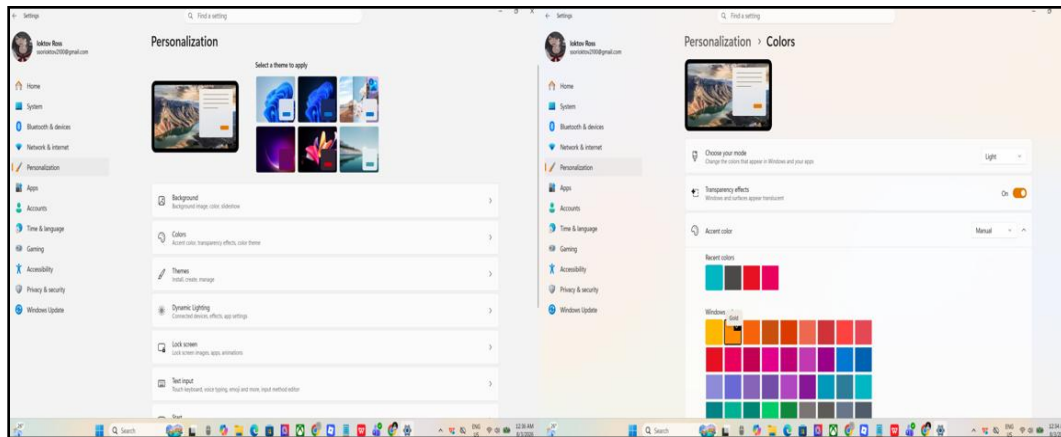
Source: [https://betawiki.net/wiki/Microsoft\\_Tips](https://betawiki.net/wiki/Microsoft_Tips)

11. Open the **Settings** app from the Start Menu.

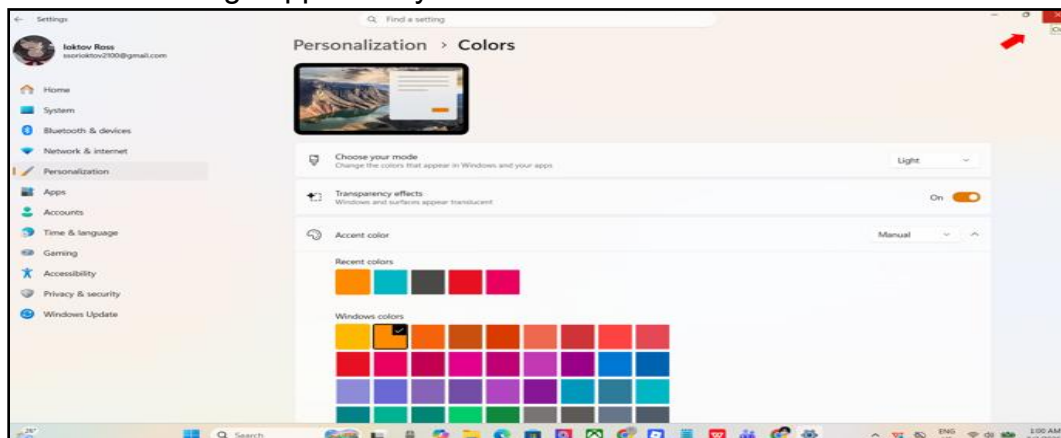




12. Navigate to **Personalization** to explore options for your desktop background, colors, and themes.

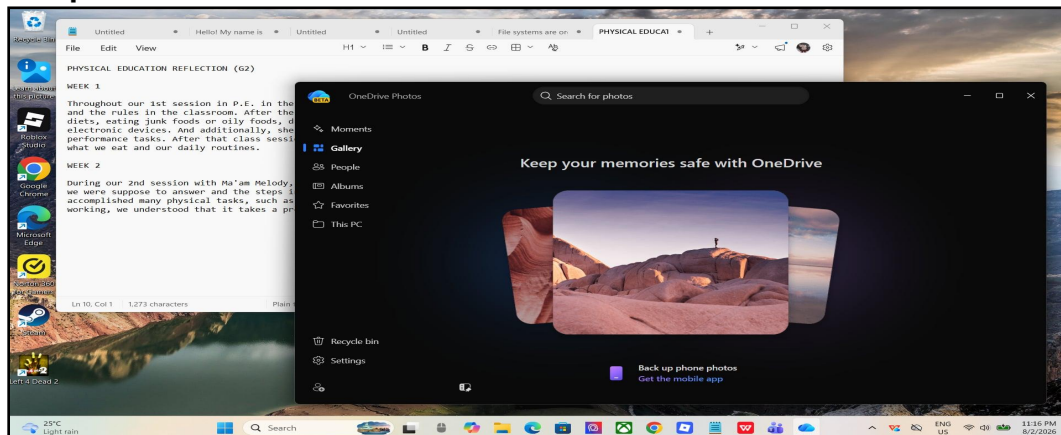


13. Close the Settings app when you are finished.



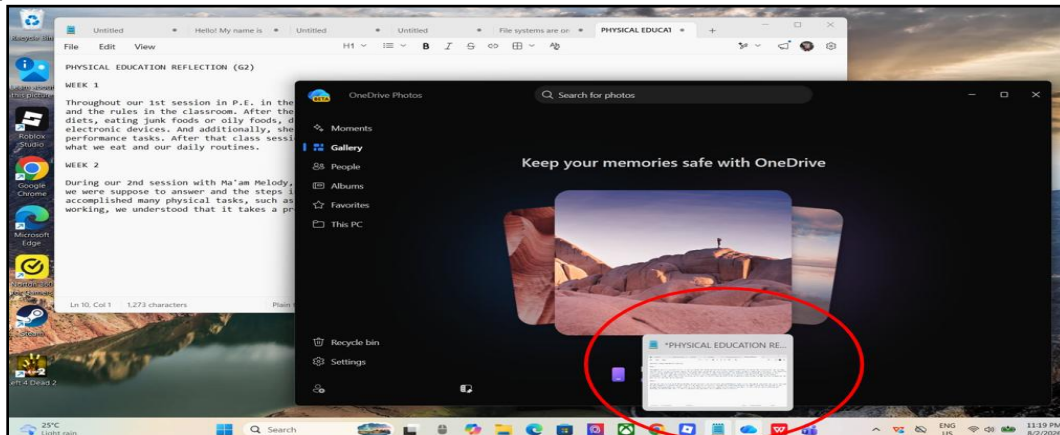
## Part II: Exploring the Desktop and Taskbar

1. Open two different applications from the Start Menu, such as **Photos** and **Notepad**.

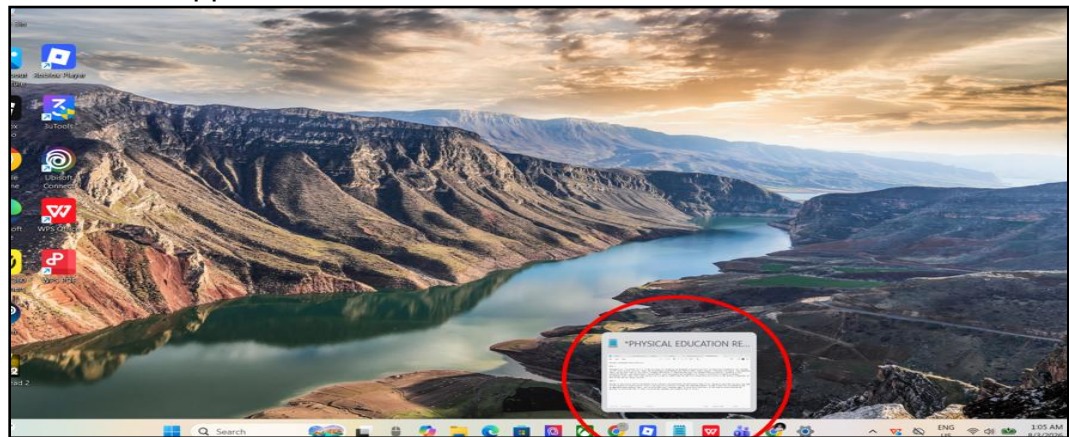




2. Observe the taskbar. Notice that the icons for open windows are now centered and do not have an underline by default. Hovering over a taskbar icon will show a preview of the window.



3. Use different methods to switch between the open windows:
  - a. Click on the application icons in the taskbar.



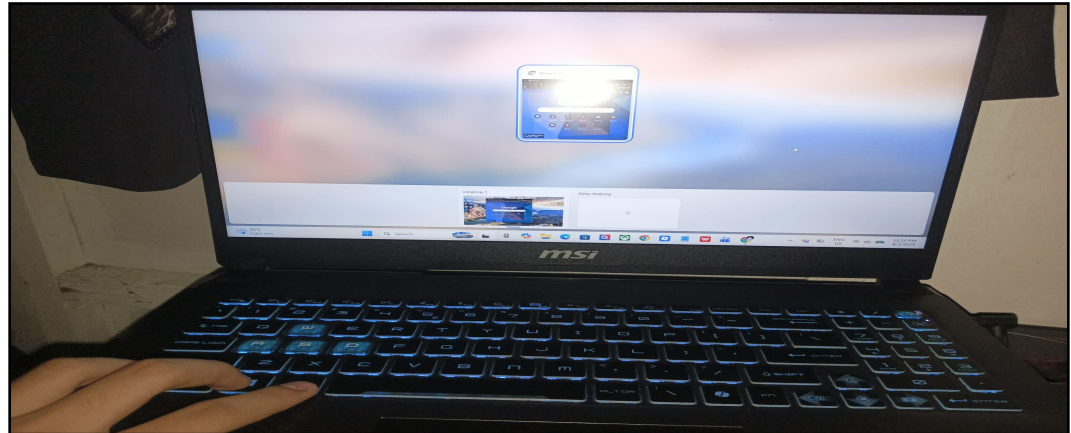
- b. Use the **ALT + TAB** keyboard shortcut to cycle through open windows.



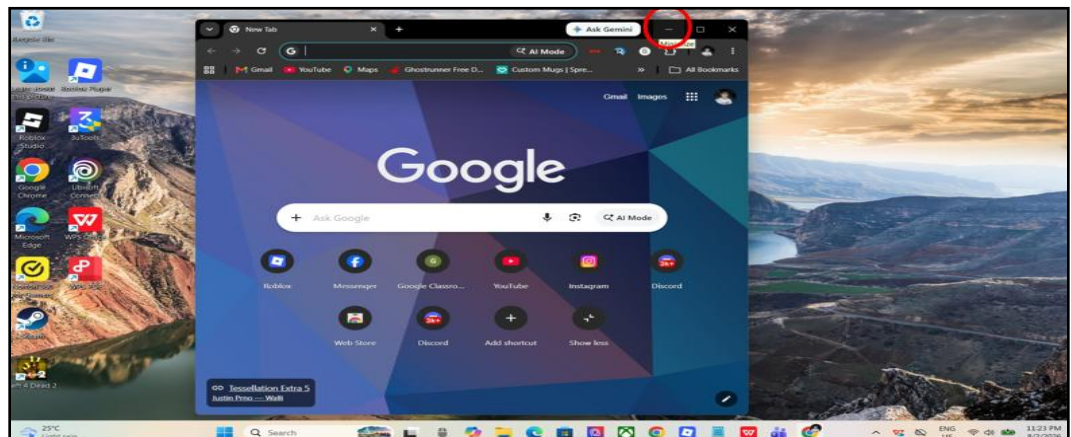
- c. Press the **START + TAB** keyboard shortcut to open **Task View**, which shows a thumbnail view of all your open applications and any virtual



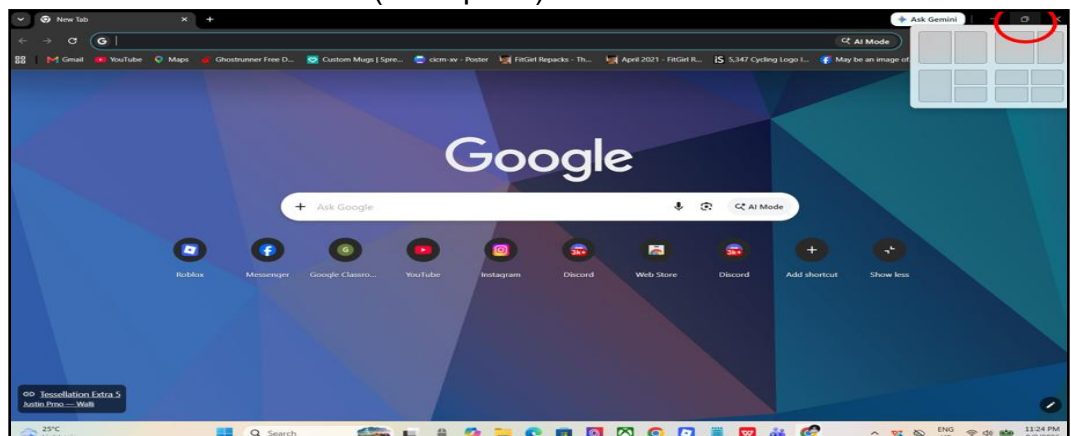
desktops you have created. Click on an app to switch to it.



4. Practice minimizing and maximizing windows:
  - a. Click the minimize button (the dash) on the window's title bar to send it to the taskbar.



- b. Click the maximize button (the square) to make the window full screen.



- c. **Pro-Tip (Windows 11 Snap Layouts):** Hover your mouse over the maximize button in the top-right corner of a window. A pop-up menu of different window layouts will appear. Select a layout to automatically



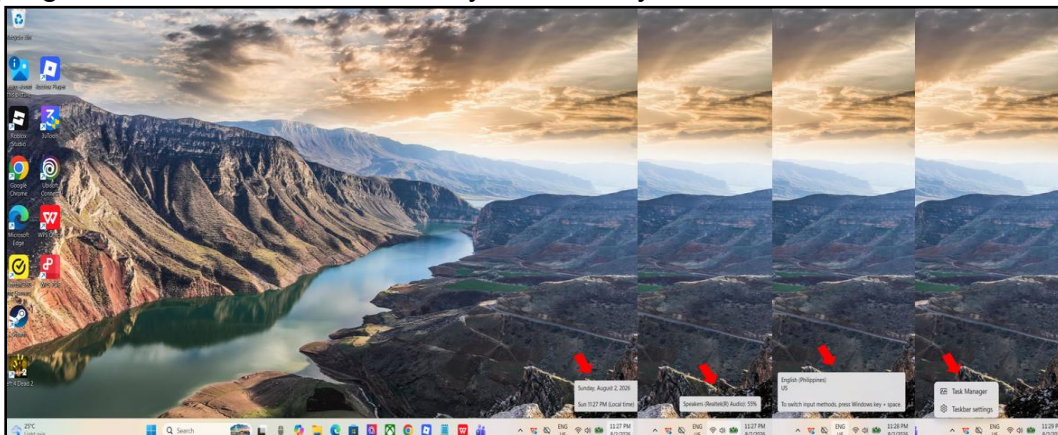
arrange your open windows.



5. Close all open windows using the close button (X) or the **ALT + F4** keyboard shortcut.

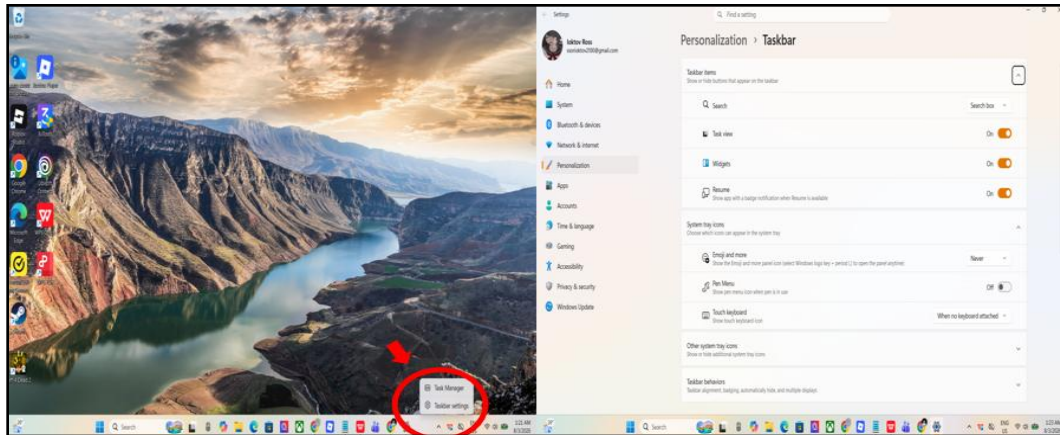


6. Explore the icons in the Notification Area (on the right side of the taskbar). Point to each icon in turn to see its description and check the status of background programs like network connectivity and battery life.

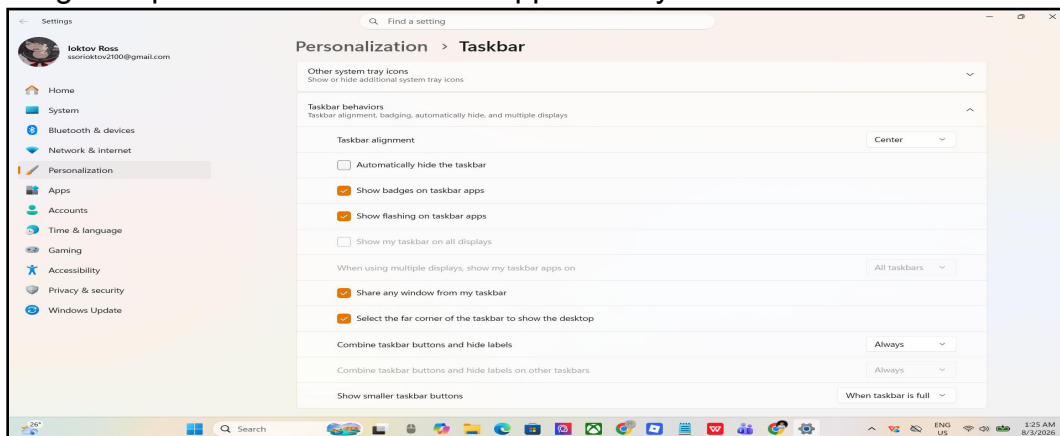




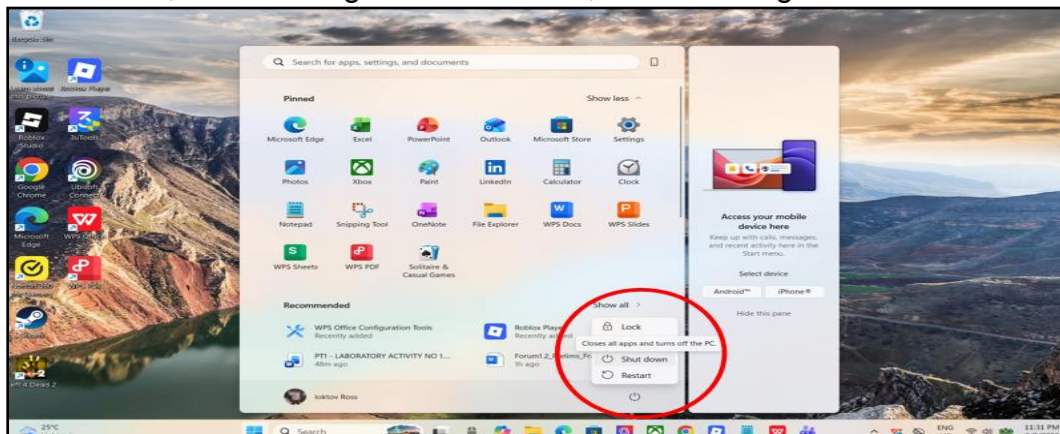
7. Right-click an empty part of the taskbar and select **Taskbar settings**. This will open a new page in the Settings app dedicated to configuring the taskbar.



8. Browse the options in the Taskbar settings to see how you can customize its behavior. You can also explore the **Start** settings tab from the left-hand navigation pane to customize what appears in your Start Menu.



9. When you have finished the lab, properly shut down the computer by clicking the **Start** button, then clicking the **Power** icon, and selecting **Shut down**.





## V. REFLECTION:

Upon successful completion of "Lab 1.2.2: Navigating the Windows User Interface," write a comprehensive reflection (between 150-250 words) addressing the following points:

- **Learning Outcomes:** What new knowledge or skills did you acquire or reinforce regarding the Windows user interface?
- **Challenges and Solutions:** Describe any difficulties or unexpected issues you encountered during the lab. How did you overcome them, or what steps would you take to resolve them in the future?
- **Real-world Relevance:** How do the skills and understanding gained in this lab relate to real-world scenarios, either in your personal life or a professional IT context?
- **Critical Thinking:** If you had to use an internet image for any step, explain why you couldn't perform the action physically and how finding the image contributed to your understanding.

Navigating the Windows User Interface helped me become more comfortable exploring the different features and accessibility options available in Windows 11. I learned how to navigate the Start Menu, Taskbar, Settings, and other built-in tools, which reinforced my understanding of how the operating system is organized and how users can personalize their experience through accessibility settings. The main challenge I faced was my unfamiliarity with Windows 11, since its layout and design are different from older versions of Windows I was used to. To overcome this, I took time to click through each menu carefully, compared it with online references, and practiced repeatedly until the interface felt more intuitive. This skill is highly relevant in real life, especially in a professional IT context, since being able to confidently navigate an operating system is a basic requirement for troubleshooting, technical support, and everyday computer use. For steps I couldn't perform physically, I used internet images to visually confirm menu locations, which helped strengthen my understanding of the interface.